Years later, when I was reinstated at the ISRO headquarters after being acquitted in the spy case, Siddharth came and hugged me.

'You should show them who you are,' he said. 'Make sure those fellows are punished.'

Being the chairman's advisor was a great elevation, but I was sure that I have to go back to Vikas engine. But as long I was here, with the additional responsibility to be the ISRO chairman's liaison officer, I would make life a little difficult for not just Gowarikar, but Muthunayagam too.

Sample this communication I sent to them. "The chairman desires an immediate report on the status of the binder VSSC is working on."

As for Muthunayagam, I bombarded him with questions about turbine motors.

The two men would have been gritting their teeth, but they had no option, but to send the reports that the chairman frequently 'desired' to see. And, on receiving their reports, I would seek a clarification. And another.

This went on for a few months, and I realised that I was not enjoying the game anymore. And the opportunity came to go back to Vikas engine as U R Rao took over as the ISRO chairman. 'You belong to VSSC,' Rao told me. 'Go fulfil your dream.'

Rao called up Gowarikar. 'I am sending Nambi back to VSSC. I have great faith in him. Hope you too will have.'

The message was clear: Don't meddle with me.

So here I was on 18 February 1985, back where I belonged, doing what I loved doing. Vikas was now part of the PSLV project. I was made the project director of the second and fourth stages (PS2 and PS4) of PSLV. Vikas, my team's tribute to Vikram Sarabhai, would soon roar to life.